

Renaming a Brand

Class 5 · Monday, September 14, 2026

Renaming a Brand

Why You Might Rename

This is a decision for THIS CLASS only. These are not reasons to rename a real business or brand.

- The name is too literal, locks you into one image
- It feels generic, you're stuck producing cliches
- You want more room for conceptual or abstract thinking
- It doesn't fit the tone, mission, or competition from your research
- You see a way to strengthen the story behind the business

When Renaming Makes Sense

These are valid reasons in practice, and here in class too.

- Name too generic to stand out (“General Computer Services”)
- Business changed what it offers (Dunkin' Donuts ↔ Dunkin')
- Name limits growth (International House of Pancakes ↔ IHOP)
- Name carries negative associations (Philip Morris ↔ Altria)
- Name doesn't translate or scale globally

The Rules

- You may rename ONE of your two businesses, not both
- Stay in the same category: nonprofit stays nonprofit, retailer stays retailer
- The business stays the business: same product or service offerings
- Document it in your process book: original name, new name, one sentence why

How to Generate Naming Options

- Mine your research: mission, competition, deep-dive notes
- Brainstorm word lists: synonyms, metaphors, geography, founder names
- Mix and match: combine, shorten, unexpected pairings
- Test for flexibility: literal and abstract, scales across applications
- Narrow to 2 to 3, pick what best fits your direction

One Way This Could Go



“Joe's” is generic and tied to one image. “Northstar” opens up navigation, guiding light, and local identity, while staying in the coffee/retail category. Renaming is a tradeoff: you risk losing some recognition, but the payoff can be a stronger, more flexible brand.

Tonight: Deep-Dive Research

How Tonight Works

- Continue working on both finalists' deep-dive research
- I'll circulate the room, I-on-I
- No narrowing today, that stays open
- Keep logging findings in your process book as you go

Coming Up

- Wed Sep 16: Mark types lecture, concept sketching begins (both businesses)
- Mon Sep 21: Critique sketches, narrow each business to one mark direction
- Wed Sep 23: High-Contrast Drawings due, digitize into refined logos

Questions?

Let's get to work.